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Chief Operating Officer, Social Security Scotland

Scottish Government

Apply before 11:55 pm on Wednesday 11th November 2026

Scottish Government
Riaghaltas na h-Alba
gov.scot

Reference number

485788

Salary

£114,714

A Civil Service Pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

SCS Pay Band 2

Contract type

Permanent

Type of role

Senior leadership

Working pattern

Full-time

Number of jobs available

1

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Location

Dundee, Glasgow

About the job

Job summary

Lead one of Scotland s largest public service operations and help shape a social security system that supports more than a third of the nation s population.

Job description

Social Security Scotland is an Executive Agency of the Scottish Government responsible for delivering Scotland's devolved social security system in line with the Social Security (Scotland) Act 2018 and our Charter.

We currently deliver 18 benefits to people on low income, disabled people, carers, young people entering employment and households requiring support with energy costs, reaching one in three people across Scotland.

This is a critical and high-profile senior leadership role, offering the opportunity to make a tangible difference to the lives of people across Scotland. The successful candidate will lead with a strong focus on performance, ensuring the effective delivery of services and outcomes, while fostering a culture of kindness, respect and inclusion for colleagues, partners and the people we serve.

As Chief Operating Officer (COO), you will operate in a highly visible environment subject to significant Ministerial, Parliamentary and public scrutiny, providing assurance to the Chief Executive on operational performance, risk, resilience and service delivery.
You will lead operational priorities that support Scotland's wider Public Service Reform agenda, driving innovation, continuous improvement and transformation to ensure services remain sustainable, effective and responsive to changing needs. You will also support engagement with Ministers and key stakeholders (Local Authorities, Health Boards third sector

partners such as Citizen Advice Bureaux etc, ensuring the organisation is well positioned to meet external expectations and accountability requirements.

Delivering critical benefit services, you will lead an operational workforce of around 3,000 colleagues (including a range of Health & Social Care professionals), primarily based in Glasgow and Dundee, with smaller teams located across Scotland. You will provide visible and inspiring leadership to these large, geographically dispersed teams while maintaining a strong focus on service excellence and client outcomes.

You will be responsible for translating organisational strategy into operational excellence, delivering high-quality, efficient and person-centred services that improve outcomes for the people of Scotland. Recognising that many of those who rely on our services may experience financial hardship, disability, ill health or other challenges, you will ensure delivery reflects the principles of dignity, fairness and respect, while building confidence through resilient and trusted public services.

As a member of the Executive Team, you will provide strategic leadership across operational delivery, organisational performance, workforce capability and financial stewardship, ensuring benefit services remain resilient, sustainable and aligned with organisational values and Charter commitments.

You will foster a high-performing, inclusive and psychologically safe culture, building organisational capability and driving continuous improvement to deliver long-term public value. Operating in a complex and highly scrutinised environment, you will demonstrate resilience, sound judgement and authenticity, leading with compassion while maintaining a clear focus on delivery, performance and outcomes for the people of Scotland.

Person specification

Responsibilities

- Lead the execution of organisational strategy, ensuring Social Security Scotland s benefit delivery is efficient, effective, compliant and focused on positive outcomes for the people of Scotland.
- Provide strategic leadership for Client Services Delivery, driving highly reliable outcomes, removing barriers to delivery and ensuring the

consistent delivery of critical services that are aligned with the values of dignity, fairness and respect and Civil Service standards.

Provide assurance to the Chief Executive Officer on operational performance, capability, financial sustainability, organisational resilience and the delivery of strategic priorities.

Drive organisational performance through the effective use of data, insight and management information, embedding a culture of continuous improvement and evidence-based decision making.

Lead and influence through others to create a high-performing, inclusive and engaged workforce, fostering a culture of openness, accountability, collaboration and continuous learning while building organisational capability and leadership capacity.

Oversee financial planning and performance, ensuring responsible stewardship of public resource and compliance with financial requirements.

Contribute and collaborate as a key member of the Executive Team, shaping organisational strategy, transformation and delivery of ministerial priorities in partnership with the Scottish Government and other key stakeholders.

Build trusted relationships with Ministers, senior leaders and external partners, providing strategic advice, assurance and performance reporting to support effective decision making and public accountability.

Support good governance, risk management and champion service modernisation, ensuring responsible use of public resources, strong operational resilience and successful adoption of new systems and ways of working.

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £114,714, Scottish Government contributes £33,232 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides (opens in a new window).

Learning and development tailored to your role

An environment with flexible working options

A culture encouraging inclusion and diversity

A Civil Service pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our candidate guidance (opens in a new window) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

Success Profile

Experience:

Proven experience leading large-scale operational delivery functions, with accountability for performance and service outcomes.

Demonstrable success leading organisational transformation and continuous improvement across complex organisations.

Extensive Board and Executive-level experience, providing strategic leadership, governance and assurance in highly scrutinised environments.

Strong track record of leading large, geographically dispersed workforces and building high-performing, inclusive cultures.

Experience leading through complex change, demonstrating resilience, sound judgement and an understanding of delivering person-centred services to people in vulnerable circumstances.

Behaviours (Level 6)

Leadership
Managing a Quality Service
Seeing the Big Picture

Communicating and Influencing
Delivering at Pace

You can find out more about Success Profiles Behaviours, here: Success profiles: candidate guide - gov.scot

How to apply

Apply online, providing a CV and Supporting Statement **(of no more than 1000 words)** which provides evidence of how you meet the skills, experience and behaviours listed in the Success Profile above. General or unrelated statements will not be accepted and may result in your application being sifted out. Please ensure that your statement clearly demonstrates how you meet the specified experience requirements. Both your CV and Supporting Statement will be used to assess your suitability against the criteria.

During the interview and assessment process, we will test your experience as well as behaviours aligned to this role.
Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools can be used to support your application, but all statements and examples provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, and presented as your own) applications will be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action.

Please see our candidate guidance for more information on acceptable and unacceptable uses of AI in recruitment.

If you are invited to the next stage, the assessment process this may include an interview with a short presentation, engagement panels, fire side chats and a psychological assessment, this is subject to change and will be confirmed if invited for further assessment

Assessments are scheduled for w/c 30 November 26, however this may be subject to change.

The Final Interview Panel will take place on 15 December 26, in person at St Andrews House, Edinburgh. Interviews will be chaired by Elizabeth Walmsley, Civil Service Commissioner. The other panel Members are:

· David Wallace, Social Security Scotland, Chief Executive

- Alison Byrne, National Records of Scotland, Chief Executive
- Deborah Rodger - Non Executive Director

Recruitment Principles

As a government organisation, we adhere to the Civil Service Commission Recruitment Principles and we investigate any complaints received in relation to recruitment cases.

Interview Expenses

Any travel and subsistence expenses incurred during the selection process are the responsibility of the applicant

About us

Led by Chief Executive David Wallace, Social Security Scotland is an Executive Agency of the Scottish Government and one of its largest public service organisations. We play a vital role in supporting people and families across Scotland, delivering benefits that improve lives and contribute to positive social outcomes. Guided by the principles of dignity, fairness and respect, we are committed to ensuring everyone can access the financial support they are entitled to, in the right way and at the right time.

Our staff are part of the , observing the and working for Ministers and senior stakeholders to deliver vital public services which improve the lives of the people of Scotland.

We offer a supportive and inclusive working environment along with a wide range of employee benefits. Find out more about .
As part of the UK Civil Service, we uphold the .

Working pattern

Applicants on any working pattern are welcome to apply for this post. If you are interested in applying on a job-share basis, please make clear in your application if you wish to be considered as a pre-existing job-share partnership or if you are interested in moving into a job-share arrangement.

We will assess proposed working patterns against the business requirements for the post and discuss all options with candidates.

Our standard hours are 37 hours per week and we offer a range of flexible working options depending on the needs of the role, including Flexi-leave.

The organisation operates on a hybrid basis, with a minimum office attendance of two days per week.

This role can be based in either Dundee or Glasgow, but regular travel will be required across all Social Security Scotland sites and to Scottish Government locations, such as Edinburgh and Glasgow, to provide visible leadership, engage with key stakeholders and support collaborative delivery across the organisation.

If you have specific questions about the role you are applying for, please contact us

Security checks

Successful candidates must complete the Baseline Personnel Security Standard (BPSS), before they can be appointed. BPSS is comprised of four main pre-employment checks Identity, Right to work, Employment History and a Criminal Record check (unspent convictions).
You can find out more about BPSS on the , and read about the , or about all of the different levels of security checks in our .
Internal candidates may need to gain higher security clearance than they currently hold if successful in their application.

Additional Security Information

Please note: in addition to the standard pre-employment checks for appointment into the Civil Service, all candidates must also obtain clearance level for this vacancy.
You will normally need to meet the minimum UK residency period as determined by the level of vetting being undertaken, which for SC is 5 years UK residency prior to your vetting application. If you have any questions about this residency requirement, please speak to the vacancy holder for this post.

Equality statement

We are committed to equality and inclusion and we aim to recruit a diverse workforce that reflects the population of our nation.
Find out more about our commitment to and how we offer and support for anyone who needs them.

Further information
Find out more about our organisation, what we offer staff members and how to apply on our .
Read our for further information on our recruitment and application processes.

For further information please visit our landing page - SSS Chief Operating Officer - Scottish Government Jobs

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a basic (or equivalent) criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is security check (opens in a new window).

See our vetting charter (opens in a new window).

People working with government assets must complete baseline personnel security standard (opens in new window) checks.

Medical

Successful candidates will be expected to have a medical.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

- UK nationals
- nationals of the Republic of Ireland

- nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS) (opens in a new window)
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)
- individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020
- Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

Further information on nationality requirements (opens in a new window)

Working for the Civil Service

The Civil Service Code (opens in a new window) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's recruitment principles (opens in a new window).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the Civil Service People Plan (opens in a new window) and the Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy (opens in a new window).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the Great Place to Work for Veterans (opens in a new window) initiative.

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : David Wallace

Email : ce@socialsecurity.gov.scot

Recruitment team

Email : scsrecruitment@gov.scot

Further information

https://fa-evxn-saasfaukgovprod1.fa.ocs.oraclecloud.com/hcmUI/CandidateExperience/en/sites/CX_1001/job/5256/?utm_medium=jobboard&utm_source=CivilServiceJobs

Civil Service Commission

disability confident EMPLOYER